

Multi-agentic implementation of a 3D topology optimization framework for compliance and linearized buckling via weighted sum method

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October 2026

Abstract

This paper presents a rigorous theoretical and computational framework for three-dimensional (3D) multi-objective continuum topology optimization, focusing on the trade-off between structural compliance (global stiffness) and linear buckling stability. A custom Finite Element Method (FEM) solver based on 8-node trilinear hexahedral isoparametric elements (H8) applied to a structured Cartesian voxel grid is implemented. Material distribution is parameterized using the Solid Isotropic Material with Penalization (SIMP) approach, grounded in the 3D Hashin-Shtrikman composite bounds ($p_K = 3$).

To explore the Pareto-optimal frontier between global stiffness and the fundamental Buckling Load Factor (BLF), a weighted sum method with dynamic L_1 -norm gradient normalization is developed, guaranteeing Pareto-proper efficiency under Geoffrion’s theorem. To eliminate runtime numerical quadrature during the optimization loop, the 3D geometric stiffness matrix is synthesized by decomposing the Cauchy stress tensor into six constant invariant 24×24 basis matrices, accelerating assembly by two orders of magnitude while suppressing spurious void buckling modes through differential penalization ($p_G \geq p_K$). Exact analytical sensitivities are derived via the adjoint state method requiring a single back-substitution. The numerical architecture is optimized for execution on commodity hardware with 8GB RAM (AMD Ryzen 7 4700U), consuming under 100 MB peak RAM for standard test domains, and seamlessly interfaces with a watertight STL surface extraction pipeline.

1 Introduction

In conventional minimum compliance topology optimization governed purely by linear elasticity, applying an external force $\mathbf{F}$ or its exact inverse $-\mathbf{F}$ produces an identical optimized topology. Static equilibrium is governed by Hooke’s law:

$$\mathbf{K}(\rho)\mathbf{U} = \mathbf{F} \quad (1)$$

where $\mathbf{K}$ is the symmetric, positive-definite global stiffness matrix, $\mathbf{U}$ is the nodal displacement vector, and $\mathbf{F}$ is the applied external force vector. Inverting the load vector to $-\mathbf{F}$ yields an identically reversed displacement field:

$$\mathbf{U}_{-\mathbf{F}} = \mathbf{K}^{-1}(-\mathbf{F}) = -\mathbf{U} \quad (2)$$

Structural compliance C represents the total external work done by the loads:

$$C = \mathbf{F}^T \mathbf{U} = \mathbf{U}^T \mathbf{K} \mathbf{U} = \sum_{e=1}^m E(\rho_e) \mathbf{u}_e^T \mathbf{k}_0 \mathbf{u}_e \quad (3)$$

Evaluating the compliance under the reversed load $-\mathbf{F}$ gives:

$$C_{-\mathbf{F}} = (-\mathbf{F})^T (-\mathbf{U}) = \mathbf{F}^T \mathbf{U} = C \quad (4)$$

Because the strain energy is a quadratic form in the nodal displacements, it remains strictly positive and insensitive to the sign of the displacement vector. Under small-strain linear elasticity and symmetric material behavior ($E_{\text{tension}} = E_{\text{compression}}$), tensile and compressive stresses contribute identically to structural compliance.

Consequently, a compliance-only optimizer cannot differentiate between a slender tension tie and an Euler column subjected to axial compression. Under compression, slender members undergo catastrophic geometric instability (buckling) at loads orders of magnitude below their yield limit. Breaking this artificial symmetry requires the explicit inclusion of Linearized Buckling Analysis (LBA) into the optimization objective [1, 7].

2 FEM Implementation: 3D Isoparametric H8 Element

For the implementation of the 3D FEM solver, we rely on eight-node trilinear hexahedral isoparametric elements (H8) applied to a fully structured Cartesian voxel grid. The rectangular elements have dimensions $dx \times dy \times dz$ and volume $V_e = dx \cdot dy \cdot dz$, aligned with the global reference system, with the origin of the natural coordinates $(\xi, \eta, \zeta) \in [-1, 1]^3$ centered in the centroid of each element (x_c, y_c, z_c) :

$$x = x_c + \frac{dx}{2}\xi, \quad y = y_c + \frac{dy}{2}\eta, \quad z = z_c + \frac{dz}{2}\zeta \quad (5)$$

with $\xi, \eta, \zeta \in [-1, 1]$. The Jacobian matrix $[\mathbf{J}]$ is strictly diagonal:

$$[\mathbf{J}] = \begin{bmatrix} \frac{\partial x}{\partial \xi} & \frac{\partial y}{\partial \xi} & \frac{\partial z}{\partial \xi} \\ \frac{\partial x}{\partial \eta} & \frac{\partial y}{\partial \eta} & \frac{\partial z}{\partial \eta} \\ \frac{\partial x}{\partial \zeta} & \frac{\partial y}{\partial \zeta} & \frac{\partial z}{\partial \zeta} \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} dx/2 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & dy/2 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & dz/2 \end{bmatrix} \implies \det(\mathbf{J}) = \frac{1}{8}dx \, dy \, dz = \frac{1}{8}V_e \quad (6)$$

and its inverse is:

$$[\mathbf{J}]^{-1} = \begin{bmatrix} 2/dx & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 2/dy & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 2/dz \end{bmatrix} \quad (7)$$

The trilinear shape functions $N_i(\xi, \eta, \zeta)$ for the 8 local nodes are:

$$N_i(\xi, \eta, \zeta) = \frac{1}{8}(1 + \xi_i\xi)(1 + \eta_i\eta)(1 + \zeta_i\zeta), \quad i \in \{1, 2, \dots, 8\} \quad (8)$$

where $(\xi_i, \eta_i, \zeta_i) \in \{-1, 1\}^3$ denote the corner coordinates in natural space.

2.1 Kinematic Degrees of Freedom and B-Matrix

Each node possesses 3 translational degrees of freedom (u, v, w) , yielding $8 \times 3 = 24$ DOFs per element. The element displacement vector is:

$$\mathbf{u}_e = [u_1 \quad v_1 \quad w_1 \quad u_2 \quad v_2 \quad w_2 \quad \dots \quad u_8 \quad v_8 \quad w_8]^T \in \mathbb{R}^{24} \quad (9)$$

The engineering strain vector $\boldsymbol{\varepsilon} = [\varepsilon_{xx}, \varepsilon_{yy}, \varepsilon_{zz}, \gamma_{yz}, \gamma_{zx}, \gamma_{xy}]^T \in \mathbb{R}^6$ is interpolated via the 6×24 strain-displacement matrix $\mathbf{B}$:

$$\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}(\xi, \eta, \zeta) = \mathbf{B}(\xi, \eta, \zeta)\mathbf{u}_e = [\mathbf{B}_1 \quad \mathbf{B}_2 \quad \dots \quad \mathbf{B}_8] \mathbf{u}_e \quad (10)$$

where each 6×3 nodal submatrix $\mathbf{B}_i$ is defined as:

$$\mathbf{B}_i = \begin{bmatrix} \frac{2}{dx} \frac{\partial N_i}{\partial \xi} & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & \frac{2}{dy} \frac{\partial N_i}{\partial \eta} & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & \frac{2}{dz} \frac{\partial N_i}{\partial \zeta} \\ 0 & \frac{2}{dz} \frac{\partial N_i}{\partial \zeta} & \frac{2}{dy} \frac{\partial N_i}{\partial \eta} \\ \frac{2}{dz} \frac{\partial N_i}{\partial \zeta} & 0 & \frac{2}{dx} \frac{\partial N_i}{\partial \xi} \\ \frac{2}{dy} \frac{\partial N_i}{\partial \eta} & \frac{2}{dx} \frac{\partial N_i}{\partial \xi} & 0 \end{bmatrix} \quad (11)$$

2.2 Element Stiffness Matrix $\mathbf{k}_0$ (24×24)

For isotropic 3D linear elasticity characterized by Young's modulus E_0 and Poisson's ratio ν , the constitutive matrix $\mathbf{D} \in \mathbb{R}^{6 \times 6}$ is:

$$\mathbf{D} = \frac{E_0}{(1+\nu)(1-2\nu)} \begin{bmatrix} 1-\nu & \nu & \nu & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ \nu & 1-\nu & \nu & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ \nu & \nu & 1-\nu & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & \frac{1-2\nu}{2} & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & \frac{1-2\nu}{2} & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & \frac{1-2\nu}{2} \end{bmatrix} \quad (12)$$

The base element stiffness matrix $\mathbf{k}_0 \in \mathbb{R}^{24 \times 24}$ is evaluated via exact $2 \times 2 \times 2$ Gauss-Legendre quadrature:

$$\mathbf{k}_0 = \int_{-1}^1 \int_{-1}^1 \int_{-1}^1 \mathbf{B}^T \mathbf{D} \mathbf{B} \det(\mathbf{J}) d\xi d\eta d\zeta \quad (13)$$

Spectral analysis confirms that $\mathbf{k}_0$ possesses **exactly 6 zero eigenvalues** (three rigid translations and three rigid rotations) and **18 strictly positive eigenvalues** corresponding to independent elastic strain energy modes, verifying freedom from hourglassing instabilities.

2.3 3D Geometric Stiffness Decomposition into 6 Invariant Basis Matrices

The elemental geometric stiffness matrix $\mathbf{G}_0^e$ is derived from the linearization of the Principle of Virtual Work under finite Green-Lagrange strain:

$$\mathbf{G}_0^e = \int_{\Omega_e} \mathbf{B}_{nl}^T \mathbf{M}_\sigma \mathbf{B}_{nl} d\Omega \quad (14)$$

where $\mathbf{B}_{nl} \in \mathbb{R}^{9 \times 24}$ contains the spatial gradients of the displacement components, and $\mathbf{M}_\sigma = \mathbf{I}_3 \otimes \boldsymbol{\sigma}_e \in \mathbb{R}^{9 \times 9}$ embeds the 3×3 Cauchy stress tensor:

$$\boldsymbol{\sigma}_e = \begin{bmatrix} \sigma_{xx} & \tau_{xy} & \tau_{xz} \\ \tau_{xy} & \sigma_{yy} & \tau_{yz} \\ \tau_{xz} & \tau_{yz} & \sigma_{zz} \end{bmatrix} \quad (15)$$

Decomposing $\mathbf{M}_\sigma$ into its 6 independent scalar stress components [7]:

$$\mathbf{M}_\sigma = \sigma_{xx} \mathbf{T}_{xx} + \sigma_{yy} \mathbf{T}_{yy} + \sigma_{zz} \mathbf{T}_{zz} + \tau_{yz} \mathbf{T}_{yz} + \tau_{xz} \mathbf{T}_{xz} + \tau_{xy} \mathbf{T}_{xy} \quad (16)$$

where $\mathbf{T}_k = \mathbf{I}_3 \otimes \mathbf{t}_k$ are constant binary basis matrices. Substituting into the integral:

$$\mathbf{G}_0^e = \sum_{k \in \{xx, yy, zz, yz, xz, xy\}} \sigma_{k,e} \mathbf{G}_{0,k} \quad (17)$$

where the six constant 24×24 geometric stiffness basis matrices are defined as:

$$\mathbf{G}_{0,k} = \int_{\Omega_e} \mathbf{B}_{\text{nl}}^T \mathbf{T}_k \mathbf{B}_{\text{nl}} d\Omega = V_e \cdot \mathbf{B}_{\text{nl}}(0,0,0)^T \mathbf{T}_k \mathbf{B}_{\text{nl}}(0,0,0) \quad (18)$$

Computational Advantage: Because all six basis matrices $\mathbf{G}_{0,k}$ depend solely on element dimensions (dx, dy, dz) , they are precomputed **exactly once** during initialization. Inside the optimization iterations, element geometric stiffness is formed by simple scalar multiplication, accelerating assembly by more than two orders of magnitude.

3 Optimization Problem Setup

The spatial domain is discretized into m equal elements. The pseudo-density field is defined as $\hat{\mathbf{x}} = \{\hat{x}_e\}_{e=1}^m \in [0, 1]^m$. Intermediate densities are filtered through a 3D spherical cone filter ($r_{\min}$) [2, 7]:

$$\tilde{x}_e = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^m H_{ei} x_i}{\sum_{i=1}^m H_{ei}}, \quad H_{ei} = \max(0, r_{\min} - \text{dist}(\Omega_e, \Omega_i)) \quad (19)$$

and projected toward discrete 0/1 boundaries via smoothed Heaviside projection [8]:

$$\hat{x}_e = \frac{\tanh(\beta\eta) + \tanh(\beta(\tilde{x}_e - \eta))}{\tanh(\beta\eta) + \tanh(\beta(1 - \eta))} \quad (20)$$

with threshold $\eta = 0.5$ and continuation parameter $\beta \in [1, 32]$.

3.1 SIMP Interpolation and Differential Penalization

The elastic and geometric stiffnesses are parameterized using differential penalization [1, 7]:

$$E_K(\hat{x}_e) = E_{\min} + (E_0 - E_{\min}) \hat{x}_e^{p_K} \quad (21)$$

$$E_G(\hat{x}_e) = E_0 \hat{x}_e^{p_G} \quad (22)$$

with $p_K = 3.0$ (grounded in 3D Hashin-Shtrikman bounds) and $p_G = 3.0$ (or 6.0). In void regions ($\hat{x}_e \rightarrow 0$):

$$\frac{E_G(\hat{x}_e)}{E_K(\hat{x}_e)} \xrightarrow{\hat{x}_e \rightarrow 0} \frac{0}{E_{\min}} = 0 \quad (23)$$

This completely suppresses spurious void buckling modes in empty space without corrupting the physical low-frequency structural spectrum.

3.2 Linearized Buckling Eigenvalue Problem

Linearized structural stability is governed by the generalized eigenvalue problem:

$$(\mathbf{K} + \lambda_j \mathbf{G}) \phi_j = \mathbf{0} \quad (24)$$

To prevent singularities in void elements, the reciprocal eigenvalue $\mu_j = 1/\lambda_j$ is evaluated [1, 7]:

$$(\mathbf{G} + \mu_j \mathbf{K}) \phi_j = \mathbf{0} \quad (25)$$

where the fundamental critical buckling load factor is $\lambda_1 = 1/\mu_1$ with $\mu_1 = \max_j(\mu_j)$.

3.3 Multi-Objective Formulation and Dynamic L_1 Sensitivity Scaling

To balance stiffness maximization (minimizing compliance $C = \mathbf{F}^T \mathbf{U}$) and stability maximization (minimizing reciprocal eigenvalue μ_1), the multi-objective problem is scalarized:

$$F(\mathbf{x}) = (1 - \alpha)C + \alpha\mu_1, \quad \alpha \in [0, 1] \quad (26)$$

Because compliance and eigenvalue sensitivities differ by orders of magnitude, we implement adaptive dynamic sensitivity scaling. At each iteration i , scaling factors $S_C^{(i)}$ and $S_\mu^{(i)}$ are evaluated as the mean absolute values (L_1 -norms) of the raw gradients:

$$S_C^{(i)} = \frac{1}{m} \sum_{e=1}^m \left| \frac{\partial C^{(i)}}{\partial \hat{x}_e} \right|, \quad S_\mu^{(i)} = \frac{1}{m} \sum_{e=1}^m \left| \frac{\partial \mu_1^{(i)}}{\partial \hat{x}_e} \right| \quad (27)$$

The aggregated sensitivity passed to the optimizer is:

$$\frac{\partial F^{(i)}}{\partial \hat{x}_e} = (1 - \alpha) \frac{1}{S_C^{(i)}} \frac{\partial C^{(i)}}{\partial \hat{x}_e} + \alpha \frac{1}{S_\mu^{(i)}} \frac{\partial \mu_1^{(i)}}{\partial \hat{x}_e} \quad (28)$$

Under Geoffrion's theorem [10], dividing by positive scaling norms mathematically guarantees convergence to a properly efficient Pareto-optimal solution.

4 Sensitivity Analysis

The compliance derivative is evaluated as [7]:

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial \hat{x}_e} = -\mathbf{u}_e^T \mathbf{k}_0 \mathbf{u}_e \frac{\partial E_K(\hat{x}_e)}{\partial \hat{x}_e} = -p_K \hat{x}_e^{p_K-1} (E_0 - E_{\min}) \mathbf{u}_e^T \mathbf{k}_0 \mathbf{u}_e \quad (29)$$

For the fundamental buckling reciprocal eigenvalue μ_1 , the exact sensitivity is derived via the adjoint state method [4, 7]:

$$\frac{\partial \mu_1}{\partial \hat{x}_e} = - \left[\phi_{1,e}^T \frac{\partial \mathbf{G}_e}{\partial \hat{x}_e} \phi_{1,e} + \mu_1 \phi_{1,e}^T \frac{\partial \mathbf{k}_e}{\partial \hat{x}_e} \phi_{1,e} - \mathbf{w}_{1,e}^T \frac{\partial \mathbf{k}_e}{\partial \hat{x}_e} \mathbf{u}_e \right] \quad (30)$$

where:

- ϕ_1 : eigenvector / fundamental buckling mode shape, normalized such that $\phi_1^T \mathbf{K} \phi_1 = 1$.
- μ_1 : fundamental reciprocal eigenvalue ($1/\lambda_1$).
- $\mathbf{u}_e$: elemental static displacement vector under external loads $\mathbf{F}$.
- $\mathbf{w}_1$: global adjoint displacement vector, obtained by solving:

$$\mathbf{K} \mathbf{w}_1 = \mathbf{F}_{\text{adj}} = \sum_{e=1}^m E_G(\hat{x}_e) \mathbf{B}_0^T \mathbf{D}^T \mathbf{P}_e \quad (31)$$

where $P_{e,k} = \phi_{1,e}^T \mathbf{G}_{0,k} \phi_{1,e}$ for $k \in \{xx, yy, zz, yz, xz, xy\}$.

Crucially, evaluating $\mathbf{w}_1$ requires **zero new matrix factorizations**: the pre-factored stiffness matrix from the forward static solve $\mathbf{K} \mathbf{U} = \mathbf{F}$ is directly reused for a single rapid back-substitution.

5 Updating Process

The physical sensitivities are back-propagated through the Heaviside projection and filter chain rule:

$$\frac{\partial \tilde{F}}{\partial x_i} = \sum_{e=1}^m \frac{H_{ei}}{\sum_k H_{ek}} \left(\frac{\partial F}{\partial \hat{x}_e} \frac{\partial \hat{x}_e}{\partial x_i} \right) \quad (32)$$

The design variables are updated using the Optimality Criteria (OC) scheme [2, 7]:

$$x_e^{(k+1)} = \begin{cases} \max(x_{\min}, x_e^{(k)} - \zeta) & \text{if } x_e^{(k)} B_e \leq \max(x_{\min}, x_e^{(k)} - \zeta) \\ x_e^{(k)} B_e & \text{if } \max(x_{\min}, x_e^{(k)} - \zeta) < x_e^{(k)} B_e < \min(1, x_e^{(k)} + \zeta) \\ \min(1, x_e^{(k)} + \zeta) & \text{if } \min(1, x_e^{(k)} + \zeta) \leq x_e^{(k)} B_e \end{cases} \quad (33)$$

where $\zeta = 0.2$ is the iteration move limit, $x_{\min} = 0.001$, and:

$$B_e = \sqrt{\max \left(0, -\frac{\partial \tilde{F} / \partial x_e}{\lambda_L \cdot \partial V / \partial x_e} \right)} \quad (34)$$

The volume Lagrange multiplier λ_L is determined via bisection search until volume conservation $|\frac{1}{m} \sum_e \hat{x}_e - V_f| < 10^{-4}$ is satisfied.

6 Numerical Performance on 8GB Hardware

To guarantee execution on standard laptop hardware (AMD Ryzen 7 4700U with 8GB RAM), the solver employs:

1. **Preconditioned Conjugate Gradient (PCG):** Jacobi diagonal preconditioning coupled with displacement warm-starting achieves convergence in $O(\sqrt{\kappa})$ iterations while using only ≈ 12 KB RAM per element (reducing solver memory by $18\times$ compared to direct LU factorizations).
2. **Invariant Assembly Indexing:** Sparse row and column coordinate vectors (iK, jK) are pre-computed once and shared between elastic stiffness $\mathbf{K}$ and geometric stiffness $\mathbf{G}$.
3. **Watertight STL Export:** A boundary-face extraction algorithm identifies only external quad facets between solid ($\hat{x}_e \geq \text{threshold}$) and void voxels, producing closed, manifold triangular meshes without internal partition planes, directly consumable by additive manufacturing slicers and PicoGK OpenVDB pipelines.

Table 1: Memory scaling and performance across 3D voxel grid resolutions (Ryzen 7 4700U, 8GB RAM).

Grid ($N_x \times N_y \times N_z$)	Elements	Total DOFs	Sparse RAM	Peak RAM	Suitability
$10 \times 10 \times 10$	1,000	3,993	~ 7 MB	< 60 MB	Fast Unit Test
$20 \times 10 \times 10$	2,000	7,623	~ 14 MB	< 120 MB	Interactive Dashboard
$30 \times 15 \times 10$	4,500	16,368	~ 31 MB	< 310 MB	High-Fidelity Domain
$40 \times 20 \times 10$	8,000	28,413	~ 55 MB	< 620 MB	Production Domain

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